

Topkapi Palace

The main residence of the Ottoman sultans for almost 400 years, the Topkapi Palace in Istanbul was also the administrative, educational and artistic centre of the Ottoman Empire. Although it was mostly built during 1460–78, later sultans made their own alterations and additions, particularly Sultan Suleyman during the period 1520–60. The vast complex comprises low buildings constructed around courtyards and linked by galleries and passages. Trees, gardens and fountains in the courtyards create a sense of tranquillity. Seclusion was one of Suleyman's priorities, so special gates, courtyards and passages were built solely for his family's use. For instance, the massive Imperial Gate was his entrance into the first courtyard, a large open space surrounded by high walls that led on to three more courtyards. The fourth courtyard was a private area for the sultan and his family, while visitors to the palace entered through the Gate of Salutation and the second courtyard. The Tower of Justice symbolizes the sultan's watchfulness, and also served as his private lookout.

